To convince the home minister of his version, Ratan argued that the fact that ‘Tata Tea had paid entirely by cheque for the hospitalisation costs was proof enough that the Company did not know the identity of the persons concerned. If Tata Tea had any bad intentions, they could have easily arranged to pay cash to a third party for picking up the bills.’

He also emphasized that the group’s social welfare schemes were undertaken ‘in the belief that this would help Tata Tea to gain support and sympathy of the Assamese people’ to ‘withstand the tremendous pressures and demands for cash contributions which Tata Tea had refused to pay’. He stressed that the allegations against the group were motivated. The meeting ended with Ratan requesting the home minister to intervene to resolve ‘the controversy’.

Though Ratan was able to make his point forcefully at the meeting, his version of the story did not gain much traction with the state government. His refrain that the group had talked to ULFA on the IB’s advice could not be independently confirmed at the time. The intelligence agency maintained a stony silence, as it does on operational issues. Under the circumstances, Ratan came under pressure and stated that the group might be compelled to pull out of the state altogether and end all its welfare schemes in Assam. He told the home minister: ‘In view of all these accusations, Tata Tea may have to close down all the welfare schemes and if the situation on the ground became one where the security of the staff and family of Tata Tea’s personnel was threatened, it may be compelled to close the Gardens down for as long as it was necessary.’

Though he had met the home minister, Ratan knew well that the only leader who could truly make a difference to their case was the Assam chief minister. As scheduled, after the meeting in the home ministry, Ratan met with Mahanta at Assam House in New Delhi. This time, Krishna Kumar accompanied him. During this meeting, Ratan reiterated the same arguments that he had made before the home minister. He scored some points when he managed to get the state Chief Secretary Vijendra Singh Jafa to admit that the government had ‘no documentary evidence that [Tata Tea] had paid cash to ULFA and others’. However, Jafa did not fight shy of reiterating that Tata Tea’s ‘help to ULFA as given to Deka was serious and the meetings with ULFA were also against the law’.

In other ways, however, the meeting further complicated matters for Ratan. During their talk, he told the chief minister that Gogoi was out of the